



MP3 PLAYERS

Portable cassette players became history when MP3 players were introduced. Initially, there were only a few models to choose from, but now they're crawling out of the woodwork!

Questions To Ask The Dealer

What is the storage capacity, and are there any additional features?

Even if you know what the capacity of a particular model is, it is better to cross-check with the dealer. Also bear in mind your growing music collection—you certainly don't want to be disappointed about your purchase a few months down the line. Ask about additional features in a model. These additional features include video playback, varied format support, and the number of colours the LCD screen supports.

Does it record?

If your job requires you to record voice when at meetings or press conferences, you will need this feature. If the player has FM radio, you should ask if it can record FM as well.

How long will the battery last, and what type of battery is it?

Most people like rechargeable batteries, while some prefer AA or AAA cells. Make sure you confirm that the battery is user-replaceable!

Does the manufacturer have service centres and how long is the warranty period?

It is important to check for warranties. Also, confirm that the manufacturer has service centres across the country.

Interesting Facts

Digital Audio Player (DAP) is the 'formal' name of MP3 player, but due to the ubiquity of the format, the name 'MP3 player' still exists. Early DAPs were CD players and mini disc players. The first non-mechanical DAP was introduced in the summer of 1998, and had 32 MB of memory. The second DAP was released in September 1998 and was a big hit; the popularity of the player was followed with lawsuits that were won by the manufacturer. The lawsuits, however, alleged that the device aided illegal copying of music.

This victory was almost the turning point; more and more companies came up with products... competition rose, and the rest is history.

Usage Tips

❑ Quite often, the earphones bundled with the player may not be top-notch. If

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you think the sound quality isn't great, try changing the earphones before returning the player.

❑ Some manufacturers provide special casings for their players to protect them from scratches and dust; if you have something like this, use it.

❑ Some players need specific applications to transfer music files to and from the player, whereas some are just plug and transfer (via the USB port).

Points To Ponder

What are the types of MP3 Players?

There are two basic types of MP3 players, Flash-based and hard drive-based. Flash-based players have memory made up of solid-state semiconductors, while hard disk drive-based players, as the name suggests, have memory units mostly made of 1.8-inch hard disks.

Which type of player suits me?

Hard drive-based MP3 players are usually more feature-rich than Flash-based ones. They normally have larger screens and a larger capacity. If you among those who listen to music while jogging and such activities, hard drive-based players are not for you. Flash-based players are very robust. They are,

however, expensive if cost per MB of storage is considered.

Which one fits the bill?

It's just a matter of the right combination of features. The supported audio formats may not be too important to you, but if you have files in other formats, say OGG, then you have to look at the supported formats very carefully. Once you've narrowed the list down to a few players that have the features you're looking for, it's time you chose a player based on your favourite brand. Brand name becomes a factor because certain manufacturers have attained popularity based on the excellence of their products, and so you are assured of quality without a doubt.

The Future

Mobile phones have started including the MP3 playback feature. This, as a matter of fact, has pushed MP3 player manufacturers into a corner, demanding more out of them at affordable costs. Flash-based drives will come with higher capacities of up to 8 GB by the end of 2006, and 16 GB by 2007.

More and more MP3 players are turning to video playback capability to gain a market advantage. In the future, we'll see almost all portable players playing back video—even DivX—and perhaps then we'll have to drop the 'MP3 player' name tag! ■